The Warrior

By Francis Richey

Her son was going to do
what he was going to do.
He was headstrong and beautiful

and couldn't imagine
he would ever die.
From where she slept in the depths

of the sea, she heard his cry
and did what sons despise:

she intervened,

commissioned divine armor,
lobbied Zeus ....
It's the same

when you see your son fall
in with a bad crowd:
he's thirteen and won't listen,

so you stop by the school
on your way home from work,
tell the principal, and quietly,

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he takes an interest in the boy.

Isn't that your job?
To whisper in the ear of
any god who'll listen: ***Please,***
protect him.

INTRODUCTION

When Frances Richey's son, Ben, a graduate of the United States Military Academy at West Point and a Green Beret, went on the first of his two deployments to Iraq, Richey began to write. The Warrior is her urgent and intensely personal exploration of what a mother is feeling as her only son goes off to war, as she says good-bye to him, misses him, prays for him, and waits for him to come home.

Poems from The Warrior by Francis Richey

That was the summer he rappelled
down mountains on rope

that from a distance looked thin
as the dragline of a spider,

barely visible, the tension
he descended

into the made-up

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state of Pineland

with soldiers from his class.
They started with a rabbit,

and since my son was the only one
who'd never hunted,

he went first. He described it:
moonlight, the softness

of fur, another pulse
against his chest.

The trainer showed him
how to rock the rabbit

like a baby in his arms,
faster and faster,

until every sinew surrendered
and he smashed its head into a tree.

They make a little squeaking sound,
he said. ***They cry.***

He drove as he told me:

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You said you wanted to know.

I didn't ask how he felt.
Maybe I should have,

but I was biting
off the skin from my lips,

looking out
beyond the glittering line

of traffic flying
past us in the dark.

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I don't remember what he'd done.
He was two. He'd done something,
and I'd read that instead of spanking,
you could put your child in a chair
and tell him to sit there and think
about what he'd done. A mother
mothered by a woman who could not
control her rages, I was determined
not to hit him. Sit here, I said, and

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put him in the little wooden chair
in the corner of his room beside the
window. Maybe he was three. All
arms and legs, he fought me. Think,
I said, as I ran for the door, closed it,
and held it closed, while he pulled
with all his strength on the other side,
Think about what you've done.

******

My son is always leaving.
Sometimes he looks back
and waves good-bye.
Sometimes he just disappears.
Where is he now?
In the air, returning from Poland?
On the ground, training at Fort Bragg?
The day he graduated from West Point,
the sun was so bright I couldn't see
the secretary of defense, a dark speck

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under the white awning
on a makeshift stage, saying something
about the world, about danger,
a different kind of war.
No one else seemed to notice
the barn swallows swoop in
like a swarm of enormous black butterflies,
their throats bloodied,
marring the brilliance of the sky.
They arrived out of nowhere,
the way my son was suddenly a man.
As each new lieutenant shook
the secretary's hand, the swallows dipped
and keened over the field, the barracks,
those gray castles of learning,
the dead generals bronzed on pedestals.
What had drawn them to this moment,
the red sash and the saber?
What had drawn my son to this life?
Where had it come from,
his certainty of purpose?

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When I was my son's age, I had no faith.
Now I believe in the prescience of wings,
each bird, its presentation of colors,
bearing the messages we pray will never come.
Looking down through borrowed binoculars
into the perfect rows,
I searched for his face.

****

Listen, dearie, there is no world without war.
An unfamiliar voice in my head --
My son is in Iraq.
I see him
in the faces of soldiers on the news,
in the Times --
The voice
in my mind, like the tune of a song
I hate but can't forget,
doesn't care about the dark circles around their eyes.
There is no world without war.

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Before he was a warrior, he was a boy;
before he drank blood, he drank milk . . . .

So what? says the voice. **We're all going to die.**

****
Before he left for combat,
he took care of everything:
someone to plow the driveway,
cut the grass.
And the letter he wrote me,
just in case, sealed,
somewhere, in a drawer;
can't be opened,
must be opened
if he doesn't return.
I feel for my keys,
hear his voice:
Less is better. Late
for work, still,
I linger
at the window of the Century

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Florist, a bowl of peonies,
my face among the tulips.

Last Mother's Day, when
he was incommunicado,
nothing came.
Three days later, a message
in my box; a package,
the mail room closed.
I went out into the lobby,
banged my fist against
the desk. When they
gave it to me, I clutched it
to my chest, sobbing
like an animal.
I spoke to no one,
did not apologize.
I didn't care about the gift.
It was the note I wanted,
the salt from his hand,
the words.

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[his letter . . . .]

THE WORST THING

... too many windows and doors.
You have to check each one: look through it,
around it, beyond it ...
. . .
You have to use the light
on your gun. That shadow
in the corner, a bad guy
can move around inside it.
. . .
When you're attacked,
you've got three to five seconds
to make the right move.
Guys get killed in the open,
when they should jump
behind a wheel well.
That's why they shoot us
again and again

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with plastic bullets for mistakes
the body makes, until it learns
to override the monkey –
adrenaline. When it's pumped,
you'll do things you'd never do at home.
. . .
360-degree security. Crucial.
If you're not sure, you have to call out
to the rear: 'Are you there?"
The whole James Bond thing looks glamorous
in film, but let me tell you, the worst thing,
the worst, is to be out there alone.

*****

I believed if I was present
for his football games,
he wouldn't get hurt;
that if I made the two-hour drive
from Stamford to Ramsey
in half the time

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that day he ran into a tree,
I could keep him
whole in his body.

Midafternoon, September,
after Beast, that first
training plebe year, I fixed
him in my mind,
and he called
later that evening: ***Mom,***
were you at West Point today?
And I said no.
But I thought
I saw you on the Plain.
I said no, but what time
did you see me?
And he named the moment
I'd prayed for him.

I thought it had something
to do with our

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heartbeats, like clocks

placed in the same

room. Once

I believed I could

close my eyes and know,

even when my son was

on the other side of the world,

if he was alive.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Frances Richey
ISBN: 978-0670019618
Publisher: Viking Adult
Date (Month/Year): April 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

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